



Christopher Musa (MOO-sah)

Minister of Defense
Federal Republic of Nigeria

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Dec 2025**

Christopher Musa is a retired general who has gone from fighting Nigeria's wars to running its military to reforming its wider security system to learning how to be a politician.

▣ The Institution Builder

Musa spent nearly four decades in uniform, leading the northeastern counterinsurgency campaign before becoming Chief of Defence Staff in 2023. His stock phrase, "unity of purpose," captures how he wants to be seen: a leader who aligns institutions and people around a mission.

▣ The Apprentice Politician

Since joining the cabinet, Musa has openly campaigned for President Bola Tinubu and Kaduna Governor Uba Sani ahead of the 2027 elections. Asked whether he was politically grounded enough to compete, he replied that he was "learning the rules."

Musa's decisiveness is both his strength and his main liability. When he believes a judgment is clear, he speaks more categorically than the public evidence supports, as when he said of a contested 2026 airstrike that "there was no innocent person there."

WHY THEY MATTER

Musa, who is one of the main gatekeeper for Nigeria's defense purchases, training, and foreign partnerships, is determined to rewrite the terms on which the country buys from abroad.

▣ The Sovereignty Hawk

Musa welcomes foreign technology, intelligence, and training, but he is sensitive to any perceived slights to Nigerian sovereignty. He rejects foreign bases, mercenaries, and any outside control over Nigerian troops.

▣ Building, Not Buying

Musa wants foreign suppliers to commit to local assembly, maintenance depots, and technology transfer through the Defence Industries Corporation of Nigeria (DICON). Off-the-shelf sales with overseas maintenance meet resistance. As he put it, "Nigeria is no longer shopping for guns; we are building the factories that will produce them."

Musa is focused on deliverables. He told UK National Security Adviser Jonathan Powell in June 2026 that "Nigeria values its historic and strategic relationship with the United Kingdom," before agreeing to review existing memoranda of understanding. With U.S. Maj. Gen. Matthew Brown in September, he highlighted Special Forces training, intelligence-sharing, border surveillance, and counter-IED support.

MEETING WITH THEM

General Musa is an engaging and warm interlocutor who is unafraid to pose difficult questions to advance his objectives.

▣ **Making it Personal**

Musa talks about personal sacrifice and shared ownership when discussing challenges. He has said that “for the first 17 years of our marriage I never spent 30 days at a stretch with my family” and stressed that “you sleep well because the military is there, sleepless, just to ensure that you go about doing your own business.”

▣ **Getting Deep**

Musa prefers to complicate, not simplify, the problem. He zooms out, reminding counterparts that extremism is “difficult to eradicate. Why? Because the center of gravity is not an individual... [it] is his ideology, and his ideology is in his mind.”

Musa adjusts his tone to his counterpart. He was brotherly with Beninese officers in Cotonou and transactional with Chinese defense executives in Beijing. He often invokes his Christian faith, vents about slow courts that free captured kidnappers, and argues that military force is only 30 percent of the security equation.

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **Nigerian Military Aircraft Crash Kills 25**

A Nigerian military plane flying from Benin City to Lagos crashed in early October in southwestern Ondo state, killing all 25 passengers and crew members. President Tinubu declared three days of national mourning and ordered flags to be flown at half-mast.

▣ **President Tinubu Returns From Vacation**

Tinubu in late September returned to Nigeria after spending several weeks in France. His staff pronounced him “hale and hearty,” but his long stay abroad has spurred new concerns about his health.

▣ **U.S. Troops Withdrawal From Nigeria**

The Pentagon withdrew about 200 troops from Nigeria who were deployed this year to help fight Islamist militants. In partnership with the Nigerian military, U.S. forces killed an ISIS commander and more than 200 militants in a series of separate airstrikes and ground raids involving MQ-9 Reaper drones and AC-130 gunships.

▣ **Nigerian Election Countdown Under Way**

In early October, Nigeria’s electoral commission marked 100 days before the 2027 presidential and National Assembly elections, scheduled for January 16, 2027 and governorship and State Houses of Assembly elections, which will be held on February 6, 2027.

NETWORK

Musa's foreign ties run through fellow soldiers rather than politicians. He has trained in both the United States and China, and regularly engages with global and regional counterparts.

Musa studied at China's National Defence University in 2012 and 2013 and took a U.S. Army War College course in 2017. He met Russian Defence Minister Andrey Belousov in Moscow in May 2025 and visited Beijing in July 2026 to pursue defense-industrial cooperation. His regular counterparts include Benin's Defence Minister Gildas Agonkan, UK Defence Minister Vernon Coaker, and U.S. Africa Command's Gen. Dagvin Anderson.

Musa, whose bond with President Tinubu rests on performance rather than long acquaintance, has become more political over time and more turf-conscious regarding other security figures.

Musa has said he did not know Tinubu closely before Tinubu made him Chief of Defence Staff in 2023 and appointed him minister two years later; Musa has since promised him "all my support," including "moving forward to the second term." While Musa and National Security Adviser Nuhu Ribadu previously had a close working relationship, there is growing evidence of underlying friction over who controls what.

CONTROVERSIES

Musa's main controversy is an allegation against the military he helped lead, which he denied and which a later official inquiry did not substantiate.

▣ Facing Human Rights Allegations

As a senior commander, Musa faced questions over alleged killings, torture, and disappearances by troops. He has denied systematic wrongdoing and says he is open to investigation. He also denied a Reuters report alleging a secret military abortion program. In 2026, he drew criticism for saying of the Jilli airstrike that "there was no innocent person there."

▣ Riled by Outside Pressure

Musa bristles at lectures on human rights, suggestions of foreign basing, and pressure to align exclusively with one partner. He has said that "no foreign country will establish a military base in any part of Nigeria." He would rather hear concerns about arms restrictions in private than read about them in the press.

Musa has twice had to correct the record. In July 2026, he denied false reports that he had resigned and threatened legal action against whoever started them. In August 2025, he clarified remarks that were widely reported as urging civilians to arm themselves, saying he meant fitness, vigilance, and self-defense skills.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Defense**, Federal Republic of Nigeria (2025 to present)
- **Chief of Defence Staff**, Armed Forces of Nigeria (2023 to 2025)
- Commander, **Nigerian Army Infantry Corps (2023)**
- **Theatre Commander**, Operation HADIN KAI, Northeast Nigeria (2021 to 2023)
- **Commander, Sector 3**, Multinational Joint Task Force, Lake Chad (2019)
- **Assistant Director**, Operational Requirements, Army Policy and Plans (2009 to 2011)
- **Operations Officer**, NIBATT 8m UN Mission in Sierra Leone (UNAMSIL) (2001 to 2002)
- **Platoon Commander**, 192 Battalion (1991 to 1993)

BIO

Musa's path as a Christian living among Muslim neighbors reflects his ability to transcend ethnic, religious, and professional divides to assume positions of power. Born on Christmas Day in 1967, his family roots are in Zangon Kataf, southern Kaduna, but his formative years were spent in Sokoto, where he attended Federal Government College before entering the Nigerian Defence Academy

▪ The Interfaith Leader

As a boy, Musa joined his Muslim neighbors' Sallah celebrations and remembers helping hold the ram before it was slaughtered. At the same time, he is a devout Christian whose parents were leaders in the local ECWA church community; his mother was known as "Maman Sokoto."

▪ The Farmer-General

Musa owns 25 hectares of land in Nasarawa State where his farm processes palm oil, manages fisheries, and raises chicken and cows. He told a news outlet that he loved farming and agricultural science was his favorite subject in high school. He also proudly served as the Managing Director of the Nigerian Army Farms and Ranches Limited in the late 2010s.

Musa is married to Lilian Oghogho Musa, who led the Defence and Police Officers' Wives Association while he was defense chief. They have four children, whom he keeps out of the public eye. Musa is a devout Christian who participates in charity events and golf tournaments. He speaks English, Hausa, and Tyap, which is the language of the Atyap people of southern Kaduna State.